



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 9.2: DYNAMIC PHRASING

Dynamic phrasing is the secret to making your melodies come alive. It's not just about the notes you play but how you play them. By mastering dynamics, you'll transform your playing into a more expressive, emotive, and captivating experience for your listeners.

WHAT IS DYNAMIC PHRASING?

Dynamic phrasing refers to the variation in volume, intensity, articulation, and rhythm within your playing. It's what adds personality and emotion to your melodies, making them more engaging and memorable.

WHY IS DYNAMIC PHRASING IMPORTANT?

1. Expresses Emotion:

- Dynamics allow you to convey a wide range of feelings, from subtle tenderness to intense power.

2. Creates Interest:

- Variations in phrasing keep your audience engaged and prevent your melodies from sounding monotonous.

3. Adds Depth to Performance:

- Dynamic phrasing brings out the nuances of a piece, adding a professional touch to your playing.
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KEY ELEMENTS OF DYNAMIC PHRASING

1. Volume:

- Use volume changes to highlight specific notes or sections. Play softly to draw listeners in and loudly to create impact.

2. Attack:

- Experiment with the force you use to pluck, pick, or strum the strings. A hard attack produces a punchy sound, while a gentle attack creates a softer tone.

3. Articulation:

- Incorporate slides, bends, hammer-ons, pull-offs, and vibrato to make your phrases more expressive.



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4. **Rhythm:**

- Play with rhythmic variations to emphasise certain notes or create unexpected pauses for dramatic effect.

5. **Silence:**

- Use rests and pauses strategically to add tension and release within your phrasing.

TECHNIQUES FOR DYNAMIC PHRASING

1. **Crescendo and Diminuendo:**

- Gradually increase (crescendo) or decrease (diminuendo) the volume of your playing to build or release tension.

2. **Accentuation:**

- Emphasise specific notes within a phrase to make them stand out. This can be achieved by picking harder or using vibrato.

3. **Note Duration:**

- Experiment with sustaining some notes longer while cutting others short to add contrast and interest.

4. **Syncopation:**

- Shift the emphasis to off-beats or unexpected places in the rhythm to create a sense of groove and unpredictability.

EXERCISES FOR DYNAMIC PHRASING

1. **Volume Control:**

- Play a simple scale, gradually increasing volume as you ascend and decreasing it as you descend.

2. **Articulation Practice:**

- Play a melodic phrase multiple times, using different techniques (e.g., slides, bends, hammer-ons) to vary its feel.

3. **Accent Shifting:**

- Take a repeating lick and accentuate a different note each time you play it.

4. **Pause for Effect:**



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- Play a melodic line and experiment with inserting pauses between phrases to create tension and release.

INTEGRATING DYNAMICS INTO YOUR PLAYING

- **Start Simple:** Choose a simple melody and focus on adding one dynamic element at a time, such as volume swells or accents.
- **Analyse Your Influences:** Listen to your favourite guitarists and identify how they use dynamics in their phrasing.
- **Record Yourself:** Play a melody and record it. Listen back and note where you could add more dynamic variation.
- **Experiment:** Don't be afraid to try extreme contrasts in dynamics to discover what works best for the piece.

APPLICATION IN DIFFERENT STYLES

- **Blues:** Use subtle volume changes and expressive bends to convey emotion.
- **Rock:** Combine aggressive picking with softer, more introspective sections for contrast.
- **Jazz:** Experiment with rhythmic syncopation and articulation to create a conversational feel.
- **Metal:** Incorporate sudden volume shifts and precise accentuation for an intense, dramatic effect.

Final Thoughts

Dynamic phrasing is what separates good guitarists from great ones. By paying attention to how you play, not just what you play, you'll unlock a new level of expression in your music. Take time to practise these techniques and integrate them into your playing to captivate your listeners with every note.

Peace,

Rob Lobasso 🧐🎸🤘